How we estimate return on investment

The math behind "8–34% projected annual return on investment"

Step 1. Add up what the degree costs

The investment has two parts: it includes what you pay for the program and the salary you give up while you are in school full time. Program cost is $83,718 for the full 20-month program: tuition ($64,800), campus fees ($3,883) and student health insurance ($15,035), from the MPDS cost sheet. Forgone earnings are 20 months of your pre-program salary.

Total investment = program cost + (salary before MPDS × 20 ÷ 12)

Step 2. Estimate how much more you will earn each year with an MPDS

Annual gain = salary after MPDS – salary before MPDS

Step 3. Divide the gain by the investment

Annual return on investment = annual gain ÷ total investment

Payback period (years) = total investment ÷ annual gain

Four scenarios

We bound the estimate with the expected range of median annual earnings for new MPDS graduates in California ($100,000 to $135,000), and with the median salaries for occupations associated with bachelor's degrees in economics ($82,329, the highest of the four fields) and sociology ($67,788, the lowest). The most conservative case is a graduate who already earned the economics median before the program and earns $100,000 after it. That case returns 8% a year. The most favorable case, a sociology graduate who earns $135,000 after MPDS, returns 34% a year. Together they give the range of 8–34%.

Salary after MPDS	Salary before MPDS	Annual gain	Total investment	Annual return	Payback
$100,000	$82,329 (economics)	$17,671	$220,933	8.0%	12.5 years
$100,000	$67,788 (sociology)	$32,212	$196,698	16.4%	6.1 years
$135,000	$82,329 (economics)	$52,671	$220,933	23.8%	4.2 years
$135,000	$67,788 (sociology)	$67,212	$196,698	34.2%	2.9 years

Projected annual ROI by undergraduate field

The projected annual ROI shown on our website for each field is a range. The low end assumes the graduate earns $100,000 after MPDS; the high end assumes $135,000. Both assume the graduate earned that field's median salary before MPDS.

Bachelor's field	Salary before	Total investment	Annual gain	Annual ROI
Sociology	$67,788	$196,698	$32,212–$67,212	16–34%
Public Health	$74,917	$208,580	$25,083–$60,083	12–29%
Geography	$78,250	$214,135	$21,750–$56,750	10–27%
Economics	$82,329	$220,933	$17,671–$52,671	8–24%

Assumptions and limits

- Salaries are medians for California occupations from Lightcast Traditional Labor Market Information and Job Posting Analytics, with bachelor's-level salaries based on Bureau of Labor Statistics data. They are not the reported outcomes of MPDS graduates, and individual outcomes will vary.
- The estimates use pre-tax salaries and do not discount future earnings growth, which should increase the ROI.
- We assume no fellowship support, no summer internship income, and no raises after graduation; each of these would raise the ROI.
- Program costs are fall 2027 estimates based on UCLA's 2026–27 fees, which may change.